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STUDY GUIDE • IEUMUN 2026

# INTERPOL

International Criminal Police Organization

Financial Sovereignty, Offshore Secrecy,  
and INTERPOL's Fight against Illicit Global  
Finance

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# Contents

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|    |                                       |    |
|----|---------------------------------------|----|
| 01 | <b>Welcome Letter from the Chairs</b> | 3  |
| 02 | <b>List of Abbreviations</b>          | 5  |
| 03 | <b>About the Committee</b>            | 6  |
|    | Mandate                               | 6  |
|    | History                               | 8  |
|    | <b>References</b>                     | 10 |

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01

# Welcome Letter from the Chairs

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A LETTER FROM

## Anastasiia Bolkhovitina

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I am so excited to welcome you to this committee. Currently, I am a third-year student in IE, and I have been an “MUN kid” since I was 12 years old. My journey spanned from being a Secretary-General of the first international conference at my Ukrainian high-school to representing IE at Navarra and Harvard Model of United Nations (overall I did more than 30 simulations, crisis most recent years, so I appreciate the chaos being well-done). I also have participated in the European Youth Parliament, which I hope will come handy in this committee too, especially its deep emphasis on understanding the problem first.

The INTERPOL topic is especially meaningful to me, since I chose to pursue a degree in Economics and International Relations, out of a stubborn belief that diplomacy is mostly economics wearing a nicer suit. So please don't just arrive with pre-written speeches. Come ready to think on your feet, to adapt, to negotiate, and sometimes to change your mind when the room gives you a reason to. We are far less interested in surface-level debate than in seeing you wrestle with how genuinely complicated this issue is. And remember that we are here to help you do exactly that, so reach out any time you have a question or even just a doubt you want to talk through.

Looking forward to meet you all,

**Anastasiia**

# Diplomacy is mostly economics wearing a nicer suit.

ANASTASIIA BOLKHOVITINA

A LETTER FROM

## João Vasconcelos Gonçalves

Hi delegates. My name is João Gonçalves. I'm 19 years old, originally from Brazil, and currently a second-year student of Business Administration and International Relations at IE University in Segovia! Model United Nations has been an important part of my life for a few years now, and I'm thrilled to continue this journey during my university years. I first got involved in MUN to improve my public speaking skills and to deepen my understanding of global affairs, but it has become much more than that, shaping who I am today.

Outside of academics, you'll probably find me doing activities outdoors or watching movies (always open to recommendations!). I sincerely hope this conference is a rewarding experience for all delegates, especially for those attending their very first MUN. Alongside the secretariat and the IEUMUN team, we're working hard to make sure our committee is engaging, inclusive, and impactful.

If you have any questions at all, feel free to reach out to me at [jgoncalves.ieu2025@student.ie.edu](mailto:jgoncalves.ieu2025@student.ie.edu)

Looking forward to seeing you at IEUMUN,

**João**

## 02

# List of Abbreviations

|                      |                                                                              |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>GDP</b>           | Gross Domestic Product                                                       |
| <b>ICPC</b>          | International Criminal Police Commission (INTERPOL's predecessor, 1923–1956) |
| <b>ICPO–INTERPOL</b> | International Criminal Police Organization (commonly INTERPOL)               |
| <b>I-24/7</b>        | INTERPOL's secure global police communications system                        |
| <b>IFCACC</b>        | INTERPOL Financial Crime and Anti-Corruption Centre                          |
| <b>IFFs</b>          | Illicit Financial Flows                                                      |
| <b>NCB</b>           | National Central Bureau                                                      |
| <b>OECD</b>          | Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development                       |
| <b>UNCTAD</b>        | United Nations Conference on Trade and Development                           |
| <b>UNODC</b>         | United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime                                     |

## 03

# About the Committee

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The International Criminal Police Organization, known as INTERPOL, is the largest police cooperation body in the world, connecting the criminal police authorities of 196 member countries through a shared infrastructure of databases, secure communications, and international alerts.<sup>1</sup>

It is also one of the most misunderstood institutions in international affairs, routinely imagined as a force of cross-border detectives able to hunt and arrest suspects anywhere on earth. The reality is narrower and, for the work of this committee, far more interesting. INTERPOL commands no officers, makes no arrests, and runs no investigations of its own. It is a network that allows sovereign states to cooperate, and its authority ends precisely where their consent does. Grasping that distinction is the precondition for any serious debate on financial sovereignty, offshore secrecy, and the policing of illicit money.

## Mandate

INTERPOL rests on the legal foundation laid down in its 1956 Constitution, where Article 2 gives the Organization two aims: to ensure the widest possible mutual assistance between all criminal police authorities, within the limits of national law and in the spirit of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, and to develop the institutions that help prevent and suppress ordinary law crimes.<sup>2</sup> Much of what the Organization can and cannot do is already contained in that wording. The clause “within the limits of the laws existing in the different countries” subordinates everything it does to national sovereignty, while the reference to “ordinary law crimes” deliberately leaves out the political, a boundary reinforced by Article 3, which strictly forbids any intervention of a political, military, religious, or racial character.<sup>3</sup> From these provisions flow the four

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<sup>1</sup> INTERPOL. (n.d.-d). *What is INTERPOL?*. <https://www.interpol.int/en/Who-we-are/What-is-INTERPOL>

<sup>2</sup> INTERPOL. (2024a). *Constitution of the ICPO-INTERPOL* [I/CONS/GA/1956 (2023)]. [https://www.interpol.int/content/download/590/file/01%20E%20Constitution\\_2024.pdf](https://www.interpol.int/content/download/590/file/01%20E%20Constitution_2024.pdf), art. 2.

<sup>3</sup> INTERPOL (2024a), “Constitution of the ICPO-INTERPOL”, art. 3.

principles that guide INTERPOL in practice: national sovereignty, respect for human rights, neutrality, and constant and active cooperation.<sup>4</sup>

In practice INTERPOL is a network, not a police force. It works through three layers:

- a General Assembly of all member states as its supreme body, an Executive Committee that oversees it between sessions, and a permanent General Secretariat in Lyon that runs daily operations;<sup>5</sup>
- a National Central Bureau in each member state, the single link between that country's police and the network, communicating through the secure I-24/7 system;<sup>6</sup>
- central databases covering travel documents, fingerprints, DNA, facial images, stolen vehicles, and wanted persons, plus eight colour-coded notices, of which the Red Notice, a request to locate and provisionally detain a person pending extradition, is the best known.<sup>7</sup>

Most relevant for us, the INTERPOL Financial Crime and Anti-Corruption Centre (IFCACC), created in 2022, coordinates the global police response to fraud, money laundering and asset recovery, and corruption, working alongside bodies such as the Financial Action Task Force and the Egmont Group of financial intelligence units.<sup>8</sup>

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<sup>4</sup> INTERPOL. (n.d.-b). *Legal documents*. <https://www.interpol.int/en/Who-we-are/Legal-framework/Legal-documents>

<sup>5</sup> INTERPOL (2024a), "Constitution of the ICPO-INTERPOL", arts. 5–32.

<sup>6</sup> INTERPOL. (n.d.-a). *Key dates*. <https://www.interpol.int/en/Who-we-are/Our-history/Key-dates>

<sup>7</sup> Global Investigations Review. (2026). Interpol. In *The practitioner's guide to global investigations* (10th ed.). <https://globalinvestigationsreview.com/guide/the-practitioners-guide-global-investigations/2026/article/interpol>

<sup>8</sup> INTERPOL. (2022, January 25). *INTERPOL launches centre against financial crime and corruption*. <https://www.interpol.int/en/News-and-Events/News/2022/INTERPOL-launches-centre-against-financial-crime-and-corruption>; INTERPOL. (n.d.-c). *Our role in fighting financial crime*. <https://www.interpol.int/en/Crimes/Financial-crime/Our-role-in-fighting-financial-crime>

**WHAT INTERPOL CANNOT DO**

- It has no agents and no power of arrest, since every arrest is made by national police under national law.
- A Red Notice is not an international arrest warrant, but a request that each member may act on or decline, and many decline.<sup>9</sup>
- It does not investigate, prosecute, or determine guilt, all of which are matters for national and international courts.<sup>10</sup>
- It is not an organ of the United Nations, but an independent intergovernmental body.
- Its Article 3 neutrality is contested in practice, as some states have misused notices to pursue dissidents and opponents under the cover of fraud or corruption charges, forcing INTERPOL to strengthen oversight through the Commission for the Control of INTERPOL's Files.<sup>11</sup>

This is the paradox at the heart of our agenda: the same instruments that let states recover stolen assets can be turned into tools of transnational repression, and a committee on financial sovereignty has to keep both in view at once.

## History

The idea of an international police body predates INTERPOL by nearly a decade.

In 1914, the first International Criminal Police Congress met in Monaco, where officials drafted early principles for cross-border cooperation and extradition,<sup>12</sup> but the First World War suspended the project. It revived in Vienna, where on 7 September 1923 delegates from twenty countries founded the International Criminal Police Commission (ICPC) under Johannes Schober, president of the Vienna police, in answer to a new generation of criminals who used cars, telephones, and open borders to outrun investigations that still halted at the frontier.<sup>13</sup> Through the interwar years, the Commission built the foundations

<sup>9</sup> Global Investigations Review (2026), "Interpol".

<sup>10</sup> INTERPOL. (2024b). *Repository of practice: Articles 2 and 3 of INTERPOL's Constitution* (3rd ed.). <https://www.interpol.int/content/download/12626/file/Repository%20of%20practice%20Articles%202%20and%203.pdf>, p. 4.

<sup>11</sup> Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe. (2017). *Abusive use of the Interpol system: The need for more stringent legal safeguards* [Resolution 2161]. <https://assembly.coe.int/nw/xml/XRef/Xref-XML2HTML-en.asp?fileid=23524&lang=en>

<sup>12</sup> Deflem, M. (2002). *Policing world society: Historical foundations of international police cooperation*. Oxford University Press.

<sup>13</sup> Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe (2017), "Abusive use of the Interpol system: The need for more stringent legal safeguards"; INTERPOL (2024b), "Repository of practice: Articles 2 and 3 of INTERPOL's Constitution".



of the modern system: a 1927 resolution urged each member to designate a central national contact point, the forerunner of today's NCB, and by the 1930s the organization had created specialized units and launched an international radio network.<sup>14</sup>

The Second World War nearly destroyed it. After Germany annexed Austria in 1938, the Nazis seized control of the ICPC by deposing its president, and its leadership passed to a succession of senior SS officers; the headquarters were ultimately moved to Berlin, most member states withdrew, and the body was no longer functional.<sup>15</sup>

## **This captured period is the reason the post-war organization treats political neutrality as foundational rather than decorative.**

In 1946, police officials meeting in Brussels reconstituted the body as the International Criminal Police Organization, with a new headquarters in Paris, and brought "INTERPOL," long used as its telegraphic address, into common use.<sup>16</sup> The modern Constitution followed in 1956, formally establishing the name ICPO-INTERPOL<sup>17</sup> and the structure that governs the organization today, and the headquarters moved to Lyon in 1989.<sup>18</sup>

INTERPOL's membership and mandate have expanded steadily ever since. From twenty founding members in 1923, the organization grew to one hundred countries by 1967 and to its present 196 in 2023, making it second only to the United Nations in membership among international organizations.<sup>19</sup> Its operational focus has widened as the character of crime kept changing, which brought us to this committee agenda of transnational financial crime.

### **TO BE COMPLETED**

The uploaded PDF ends after the History subsection. Add the remaining sections from the full Word document (topic background, current situation, bloc positions, questions a resolution must answer, further reading).

<sup>14</sup> INTERPOL (n.d.-a), "Key dates".

<sup>15</sup> Deflem (2002), *Policing world society: Historical foundations of international police cooperation*; INTERPOL (n.d.-a), "Key dates".

<sup>16</sup> Deflem (2002), *Policing world society: Historical foundations of international police cooperation*; The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica. (2024). *Police: International police organizations*. Encyclopædia Britannica. <https://www.britannica.com/topic/police/International-police-organizations>

<sup>17</sup> INTERPOL (2024a), "Constitution of the ICPO-INTERPOL", art. 1.

<sup>18</sup> The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica (2024), "Police: International police organizations".

<sup>19</sup> Wood, M. (2026). INTERPOL as an international organization. *AJIL Unbound*, 120, 11–16. <https://doi.org/10.1017/aju.2025.10044>

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